

IK 559: Three Short Upaniṣads

Course Code : IK 559

Course Name : Three Short Upaniṣads

L-T-P-C : 3-0-0-3

Intended for : BTech/MTech/MS/MSc/MA/Ph.D

Prerequisite : IK 541

Mutual Exclusion: None

Approval: 42nd Senate

Course Contents

- **Introduction to the Kena Upaniṣad:** The Kena Upaniṣad is an Upaniṣad of the Sāma Veda and is to be found in the Talavakara or Jaiminiya branch of the Sāma Veda. For this reason, it is sometimes referred to as the Talavakara Upaniṣad. It forms a part of the Jaiminiya Brahmana of the Sāma Veda (4.18-21) but is usually regarded by Hindu authorities as a separate work. (6 hours)
- **Kena Upaniṣad (part two):** Chapter 2 is composed in verse form and presents a description of Brahman as the ultimate truth that lies behind all forms of existence. It also discusses the process of knowing Brahman as a means of attaining release from this world. (6 hours)
- **Kena Upaniṣad (part three):** Chapters 3 and 4 adopt a narrative structure, though again the main purpose behind the discourse is the revelation of Brahman as the ultimate principle that transcends even the gods who are praised in the hymns of the Veda Samhitas. Here perhaps we get some indication of a Supreme Deity who possesses a personal identity, though this idea cannot be said to be prominent within the Kena Upaniṣad. (5 hours)
- **Īśa Upaniṣad (part one):** We move on to consider another of the most important Upaniṣads, the Īśa or Īśāvāsyā, and here we have full commentaries from both an Advaitic and a Vaishnava perspective, which will provide interesting parallels. Shankaracharya has left us a full commentary on all eighteen verses, whilst Swami Prabhupada, the founder of ISKCON, made his own commentary from a Vaishnava or dualist perspective. Unit 5: Īśa Upaniṣad (part two) (4 hours) This Upaniṣad seems to be about the inner Self as the ultimate principle, which can hence be referred to as God, the Īśa. It is about the absolute transcendence of the Atman over the limitations that prevail in this world. And it is about moksha as the relief from suffering attained by one who can perceive the Atman. The final four verses are included to demonstrate that these ideas are not to be regarded as non-Vedic, for if one understands them properly then one can see that the Vedic hymns themselves are saying the same thing. (6 hours)
- **The Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad (part one):** We now consider the Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad, which was also very highly regarded by Shankaracharya. The Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad is significant for its revelation that the syllable 'om' is identical with Brahman, and today the omkāra is often used to represent Hindu Dharma. Furthermore, Gaudapada wrote an extensive treatise or Kārikā on the Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad in which we find an early exposition of the principles of Advaita Vedānta. (8 hours)
- **Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad (part two):** In this session, we will look at the final four verses of the Māṇḍūkya and then briefly consider Gaudapada's Kārikā on it, which was very influential for Shankara in his establishing the doctrines of the Advaita Vāda. (6 hours)

Textbooks:

1. Sri. M, **Wisdom of the Rishis: The Three Upanishads: The Three Upanishads, Īśāvāsyā, Kena, and Māṇḍūkya.**
2. Eknath Easwaran, **The Principal Upanishads**, 1982.
3. Patrick Olivelle, **The Upanishads: A New Translation**, 1996.

References:

1. Black, Brian, **The Upanishads**, *Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.
2. Brodd, Jeffrey, **World Religions: A Voyage of Discovery**, Saint Mary's Press, 2009.
3. Brooks, Douglas Renfrew, **The Secret of the Three Cities: An Introduction to Hindu Shakta Tantrism**, The University of Chicago Press, 1990.
4. Brown, Rev. George William, **Missionary review of the world**, vol. 45, Funk & Wagnalls, 1922, archived from the original on 2 October 2022, retrieved 22 November 2020
5. Chari, P. N. Srinivasa, Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan (ed.), **History of Philosophy Eastern and Western**
6. **Upanishad** Archived 20 September 2014 at the Wayback Machine. ,Random House Webster's Unabridged Dictionary.
7. A Bhattacharya, **Hindu Dharma: Introduction to Scriptures and Theology**, 2006 pp. 8–14.
8. George M. Williams, **Handbook of Hindu Mythology**, Oxford University Press, p. 285, 2003.
9. Jan Gonda, **Vedic Literature: (Saṃhitās and Brāhmaṇas)**, Otto Harrassowitz Verlag, 1975.
10. <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Upanishads>